to proceed any further for fear of the Chinese, so their loads had to be divided amongst the already overloaded and exhausted troops. Alpha Company finally reached its destination, PT 3466, by the next afternoon. Nair was then told by Avasthy on the radio to dig in and start preparing the defences; further instructions would follow.

The second infantry battalion under 65 Infantry Brigade was 19 MLI. Formerly the Kolhapur State Force, the battalion had been earlier deployed in Nagaland from where it had moved to Alipur near Calcutta when it was rushed back to NEFA. By 9 November, it had reached Bomdila from where it was ordered to move further up to Dirang Dzong.

Dirang Dzong was occupied by 4 Division HQ that was housed in a stone building with smartly constructed bashas on the southern bank of the Khouma Chu. Sharing the space was 4 Artillery Brigade, under Brigadier Gurbax Singh Gill. 65 Infantry Brigade was located at Ewang, close to Sapper's Camp. 19 MLI was accordingly ordered to co-locate itself at Ewang where, minus two of its companies, it was deployed for the protection of the Brigade HQ. The remaining two companies were asked to proceed to PT 2090 where they occupied the two banks of the Khouma Chu.

IN THE FOOTSTEPS OF MORSHEAD AND BAILEY

Ever since the decision had been taken to dig in at Se-la, the threat of infiltration along flanking tracks was constantly being discussed at every level. Yet, Anant Pathania did not seem to be taking it seriously. Perhaps he felt that the Chinese could at best send small parties across that would be dealt with by Indian posts sitting on the southern side of the passes through which the tracks traversed. Latching onto the 'small party' factor, right down from Army HQ to corps to division, it was taken as gospel that not more than a Chinese company could negotiate Poshing-la. As noted before, if a company can get across a geographical feature, there is no reason why a battalion or a regiment cannot do the same, especially as the limiting factors are logistical and not physical. The major Chinese thrust, the Indians were convinced, would actually come along the main road between Jang and Nuranang. Having fixated on this, the senior officers displayed a remarkable sense of rigidity and refused to look at other possible approaches that could be utilized by the Chinese.